Pakistan. It was winter and the snow-covered Himalayas prevented any immediate Chinese intervention. Nixon was too bogged down in Vietnam to do more than issue threats. On 16 December, the Pakistanis signed the instrument of surrender in Dacca. Thus, Bangladesh was born. However, given its implied acquiescence, the international community has conveniently forgotten about the genocide and no Pakistani official has ever been indicted for it.

In 1975, India absorbed the protectorate of Sikkim into the Union. The principality had been ruled by the Chogyal, a ruler of Bhutiya extract, who was unpopular with the ethnic Nepali majority. This led to constant friction and demands for popular representation. The Indians were also concerned that the Chinese would press claims that Sikkim was part of Tibet and move in. When elections were finally held, the anti-monarchist Sikkim National Congress won all the seats but one. The Chogyal was forced to abdicate and a referendum in April 1975 overwhelmingly voted to join India. My father was one of the first Indian officials sent in to manage the handover and administer the new state. Thus, my earliest memories are of the beautiful snow-clad peaks of the Kangchenjunga. As one can see, it took almost three decades after British withdrawal for the national borders of the subcontinent to look like what we know them today. They are still not set in stone. India has serious border disputes with China and Pakistan. Even with Bangladesh, there are issues left over from Partition involving tiny enclaves that lie trapped within each other’s territory.

MODERNIST BRUTALITY

Almost a century ago, Mahatma Gandhi is said to have commented that ‘India lives in its villages’. This was not a comment on population statistics but one about the soul of India. It is a deeply ingrained view that India is somehow a fundamentally rural country, unchanging and eternal. Yet, for all the extraordinary continuities of Indian civilization, the country has gone through many dramatic changes and cycles of urbanization over the millennia. By all indications, it is now embarking on a phase of rapid